

A Short Story: Eating Alone [C1]

Per il protagonista di questo racconto, il cibo non è solo nutrimento: è un piacere da condividere. Non trovando l'appoggio della moglie, cercherà compagnia in una tenera famiglia di procioni.

"There you are again," said Greta. "What are you staring at the fridge for? This is not the Netflix catalogue for you to browse for hours on end. Just pick something!" As usual, his wife was right. It might well have been the third or fourth time he had opened the fridge since getting home from work that afternoon. The fridge was already beeping in warning, but he was unable to make up his mind. He was trying to give shape to an indefinite craving, assign a texture and a taste to whatever his brain was nudging him to want. Sweet or savoury? At that time of the night (and at his age), the sensible choice would have been a light snack, a salad, or a piece of fruit. But his anxiety pushed him towards something hyper-caloric and filling. More than nourishment, a night meal ought to be entertaining; crunchy, noisy, something he could eat with his hands, or devour by the spoonful from a large bowl on his lap. "Remember, I'm saving the yoghurt with muesli and berries for tomorrow, when I break my fast." Ever the judicious one, Greta had taken up intermittent fasting shortly after the twins left for college at the end of the summer. Almost nine months on, and she said she hadn't felt so energised since before having the kids. He, meanwhile, remained devoutly committed to permanent breakfasting. And it showed in his waistline. He opted for the elaborate and prepared his favourite sandwich: pastrami and cheese with pickle butter on wholegrain bread. It had taken him years to perfect the recipe. "Culinary-award material," he thought as he grabbed a couple of beers from the fridge and headed out into the cool spring evening on his front porch. It was peaceful on the quiet cul-de-sac, but he felt a prick of sadness in his chest. He disliked eating alone. He missed sharing meals with his wife and children. Food is not just sustenance, he thought. Food is meant to be shared. Otherwise, it's just fuel. Fiction

A Short Story: Hot Cakes Non si paga solo il prodotto: si paga l'esperienza. È questa la conclusione a cui è arrivata la protagonista di questa storia dopo

aver provato i migliori scone della città. Rachel Roberts, Rachel Roberts Biting into his sandwich — wondering, not for the first time, what the Pulitzer for sandwiches might be called — and [sipping](#) a not-so-cold beer in a [folding chair](#), he heard one of those nocturnal noises that could have been anything. Putting on his glasses, he saw shadows moving next to the [bins](#). “[Raccoons!](#)” he whispered to himself. It was a family of four, a parent and three [young](#), [rummaging](#) through the [bins](#) and sharing their discoveries between them: last night’s takeaway chicken-wing bones, an apple core, an empty yoghurt container, some [overripe berries](#). Watching them eat brought him pure joy. When the parent [locked eyes](#) with him and the three [offspring](#) noticed, all five of them stared at one another for what seemed like a very long time. They [munched](#) in peace and he [chewed in awe](#), feeling what could only be described as happiness. The following night, he waited for them to show up again. And they did. He [slurped](#) instant noodles while they [nibbled stale](#) bread, some [cheese rinds](#), and more yoghurt. On the third night, he ate frozen pizza, and the [furry](#) family helped themselves to some banana skins and the remains of a salad. On the third, the family looked at him in disappointment — there were hardly any [leftovers](#) in the bin, only Greta’s usual pot of [goat’s](#) yoghurt. They [licked it clean](#) and moved on up the road, disappearing into the dark. The thought of the raccoon family eating someone else’s [leftovers](#) filled him with a jealousy he hadn’t felt for decades. The next day after work, he went to the supermarket and prepared a splendid buffet. He googled what raccoons eat in the wild and tried his best to replicate their favourite diet: a bunch of grapes, four apples, two [corncobs](#), six hard-boiled eggs, and two cartons of orange juice. But the raccoons wouldn’t touch the catering [laid out](#) on the [curb](#). They went straight back to the [bins](#), then left again, disappointed. Early the next night, while Greta was still watching some Netflix show or other, he dressed in a black sweater and [sweatpants](#) and went down the road. As silently as he could, he collected as many [leftovers](#) as possible from his neighbours’ [bins](#) and placed them in his own bin. “Hey Rob! Don’t you live up in Catamount Valley?” asked Tony from across the lunchroom at the factory. Everyone turned their heads. “Haven’t you been [raided](#) by the Fattycoon yet?” he said, and [burst out laughing](#). “What do you mean?” he asked. He was feeling groggy after five nights in a

row [scavenging](#) for [leftovers](#) and waiting for the raccoons to come for dinner. "Haven't you seen the videos?" Tony replied, handing him his phone. The original video was [blurry](#). Recorded at night, you could hardly discern in it the shape of an animal or a person, with its head in a bin. Someone had filmed the scene from a window and uploaded it with the caption, "[Raccoons](#) are gigantic now!!!" The news spread rapidly, and in a few hours dozens of memes and parodies [popped up](#) all over. The internet [jury was still out](#) as to what the new creature should be called: the Fattycoon was an early favourite along with the [Humongous Snacker](#), [Potbelly Bigfoot](#), and the [Masked Muncher](#), but Tinyhands McMassive was gaining traction. That night, a handful of influencers arrived in the neighbourhood, carrying their phones with tripods and lights, hoping to [catch a glimpse](#) of Tinyhands McMassive and [hit the viral jackpot](#). With all that attention, he knew the family would never return. For him, it was back to eating alone or else fasting in company.

Glossary

- **hit the viral jackpot** = vincere la lotteria
- **savoury** = salato
- **young** = cuccioli
- **munched** = divorare
- **furry** = pelosa
- **Potbelly Bigfoot** = Bigfoot Panzuto
- **catch a glimpse** = intravedere
- **pickle butter** = burro aromatizzato ai cetriolini
- **offspring** = prole
- **nibbled** = rosicchiare
- **goat** = capra
- **sweatpants** = pantaloni della tuta
- **Masked Muncher** = Divoratore Mascherato
- **break my fast** = rompere il digiuno
- **prick** = fitta
- **sipping** = sorseggiare
- **cheese rinds** = croste di formaggio
- **corncobs** = pannocchie
- **burst out laughing** = scoppiare a ridere
- **nudging** = spingere
- **wholegrain bread** = pane integrale
- **cul-de-sac** = vicolo cieco
- **overripe** = troppo maturi
- **slurped** = risucchiare rumorosamente
- **stale** = duro, secco
- **curb** = bordo del marciapiede
- **Humongous Snacker** = Enorme Ghiottone
- **devour by the spoonful** = divorare a cucchiariate
- **lap** = grembo
- **rummaging** = frugare
- **licked it clean** = leccare fino a lasciare pulito
- **blurry** = sfocato
- **berries** = frutti di bosco

- **folding chair** = sedia pieghevole
- **in awe** = meravigliato
- **leftovers** = avanzi
- **chewed** = masticare
- **for hours on end** = per ore e ore
- **craving** = voglia
- **sensible choice** = scelta sensata
- **nourishment** = nutrimento
- **sustenance** = sostentamento
- **bins** = bidoni della spazzatura
- **Raccoons** = procioni
- **waistline** = girovita
- **locked eyes** = incrociare gli sguardi
- **laid out** = disporre
- **raided** = assaltare, saccheggiare
- **scavenging** = rovistare
- **popped up** = comparire all'improvviso
- **jury was still out** = non c'è ancora un verdetto